power. The Great Leap Forward from 1958 to 1962 had backfired, and his leadership was under challenge within the communist party. In 1966, China was in the throes of the Cultural Revolution, and once again Mao was preoccupied with domestic politics.

The drift towards a détente and a subsequent partnership against the Soviets soon resumed. Thanks to America's involvement in the Vietnam war, the US presidential election of November 1968 brought Richard Nixon to power. A confirmed Cold War hawk, Nixon had made known his by-then dovish views on China. Writing in the American journal *Foreign Affairs* in 1967, he argued that the US must engage the communist Chinese leadership:

> Taking the long view, we simply cannot afford to leave China forever outside the family of nations . . . China, within three to five years, will have a significant deliverable nuclear capability . . . For the short run, then, this means a policy of firm restraint . . . designed to persuade Peking that its interests can be served only by accepting the basic rules of international civility. For the long run, it means pulling China back into the world community . . .[15]

Nixon's intent was not just integrating China into the international system more fully. It was also to take advantage of the Sino-Soviet split and turn Beijing more decisively against Moscow so as to tilt the balance of power in favour of the US. In China, Mao read Nixon's article and perspicaciously concluded that if the Republican aspirant came to power the US would be looking to engage diplomatically with Beijing.[16]

The Nixon opening to China was matched by a Mao opening to the US. The Chinese, picking up on cues from the mid-1960s and the Nixon article, played their America card. On 26 November 1968, just days after the US presidential elections brought Nixon to power, it nudged Washington. It proposed that the ambassadorial talks with the US, which had been held intermittently since 1955, be reconvened (the same talks India had played a role in encouraging after the Korean war). Beijing's message was duly received in Washington. Before Nixon was inaugurated as president in January 1969, he and his advisers were already chalking out a response.[17]